

MONSTER CROC

DEINOSUCHUS

Related to but probably much larger than modern-day alligators and caimans, *Deinosuchus* was a gigantic, semiaquatic hunter. This powerful predator lurked in the estuaries and coastal waters of the ancient Western Interior Seaway during the Cretaceous Period. Most of what is known about *Deinosuchus* comes from the remains of a few fragments, which have been used to reconstruct its skeleton. This has made it tricky for paleontologists to estimate its size, but most agree that it could have been as large as 20–26 ft (6–8 m), with perhaps the oldest and largest individuals reaching 33 ft (10 m) in length.

Rows of bony plates lined the back, providing *Deinosuchus* protection from predators.

A powerful tail helped *Deinosuchus* propel itself through the water.

GROWING UP

A full-size *Deinosuchus* such as this one would have grown up to 33 ft (10 m) long. However, it only reached this size after slow and steady growth over several decades, with youngsters growing up to 12 in (30 cm) every year. Modern crocodylians, on the other hand, grow rapidly as hatchlings, then at a slower rate as they get older.

